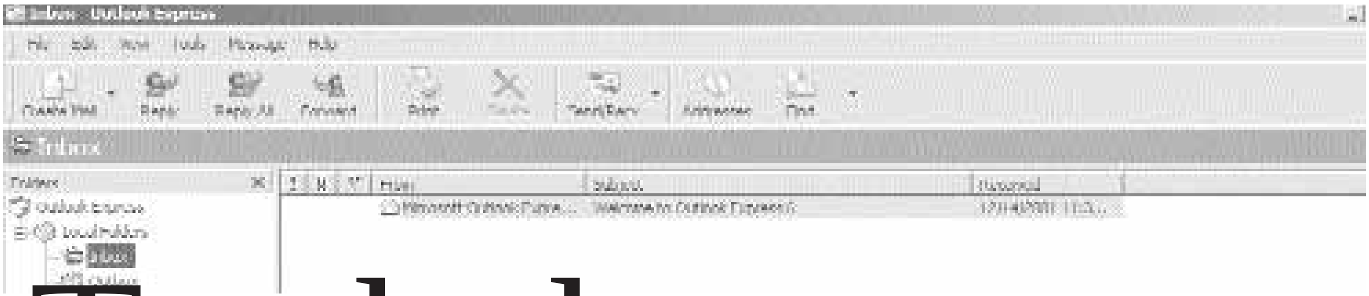


Track that nasty e-m@il!

It's time to stop being a victim. Turn the tables on vicious spammers

Romeo53@dhakdhak.com is at it again! You're looking at the 38th message you've received in the last couple of weeks from this e-mail address. It also digs out from the dark recesses of your consciousness that disturbing e-mail you received from another unknown person. You wish you could find out who's behind all of this. Spam and more spam, anonymous e-mail from people you can't identify.

This seamy, not-so-great side of the Internet is something we're all familiar with. Sure, you can always hit the [Delete] key, but wouldn't you rather find out who is behind this nuisance and put a final stop to the invasion of your Inbox?

On the digital trail

Just as a physical letter has an origin and path by which it travels to the receiver, e-mail too originates from somewhere, that is, the machine it was sent from and the path by which it travelled to you; for example different mail servers that carry the message. The same holds true for spam, though most bulk e-mail messages originate from List serve IDs (automated mailing lists). Similarly, an anonymous post directed at someone in a newsgroup originates from a news server.

Hence, it's possible to trace an anonymous e-mail to the machine it was sent from or at least tell whether the e-mail address is genuine or fake.

There are several possibilities when it comes to the origin of an anonymous mail. The most common one is when a person creates a fictitious e-mail ID at a site of a prominent e-mail service provider, such as Yahoo! or Hotmail, and sends e-mail from that ID. In this case what you could do is send an e-mail to abuse@e-mailprovider.com with a copy of the mail that you received. For example: abuse@yahoo.com if you receive a mail from a Yahoo! ID or the postmaster at the Web site from which you received the mail.

If it's a well-known mail service provider, such matters are taken very seriously and the particular e-mail ID will be blocked. But that won't solve the problem, as it's very easy for the person to register another fake ID at some other site and continue spamming you.

Reading e-mail headers

When you receive an e-mail, it seems as though the mail reached you directly from the sender's machine. But that's not how it happens. Typically, an e-mail passes through at least four computers on its way from sender to receiver.

Every e-mail comes accompanied with information about the path that it travelled. This information is in its header. That's the place you should look at first while trying to trace a mail.

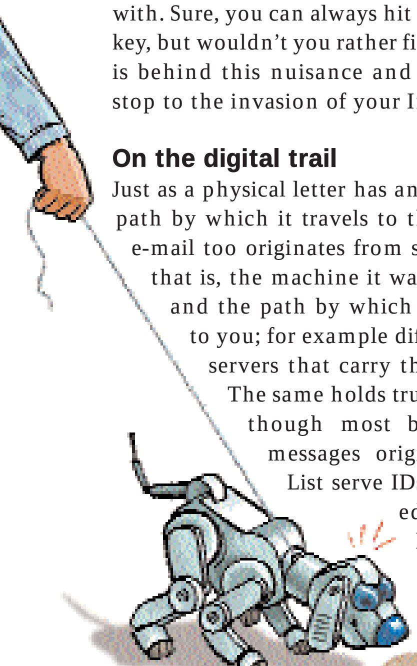
If you're using a mail client such as Outlook Express or Netscape Communicator, right-click the mail and select Properties or open the mail and go to ***File > Properties***. You'll see a screen with two tabs. The General Tab will give you basic

Armed for Defence

Arm yourself with these useful tools to help you find who's bothering you online.

TJPing, a utility available at ***www.topjimmy net/tjs***, performs ping and Traceroute functions and looks up IP addresses. While doing a Traceroute, try and avoid confusion by using Ping Plotter, a visual Traceroute program available as freeware as well as shareware at ***www.nessoft.com/pingplotter/download.html.***

Neotrace Express and Neotrace Pro at ***www.neoworx.com/download/default.asp*** help you trace the source of an e-mail and protect yourself.



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